

Last year, when our grocery budget was super tight, and I mean *super*, I tried to see what we already had in our pantry to create meals rather than head to the grocery store. I came up with seven (yes, seven!) extra dinners with a simple food inventory and pairing ingredients I already had. It took about twenty to thirty minutes, but helped us delay that grocery trip a little while longer. It was great to use up some of the ingredients I had forgotten about too!

Here's an example of the ingredients I had and what I could make:

- Ground beef + BBQ sauce + ketchup + hamburger buns = Sloppy Joes
- Lettuce + cheese + dressing + croutons = Salads
- Canned soup + bread + cheese = Grilled Cheese Sandwiches and Tomato Soup
- Chicken + cream of chicken soup + cheese + broccoli + bread crumbs = Chicken Casserole
- Chicken + bread crumbs + eggs + seasonings = Popcorn Chicken
- Pasta + cheese = Mac n' Cheese
- Noodles + sauce + cheese + seasonings = Pasta Dish

I encourage you to go through your pantry, fridge, and freezer today and see what meals you can brainstorm based on the ingredients you have. The Shop Your Stock Worksheet will help, and is available at

CreativeSavingsBlog.com/ExpenseResources

2. MAKE BUDGET-FRIENDLY MEALS

Whenever you plan weekly or monthly meals (which saves you time and money), focus on recipes that cost less than \$1/serving. This stretches the